

PC Appears Critical

Q My PC configuration is as follows: an Intel Pentium IV 2.4 GHZ, 256 MB DDR RAM, a Seagate Barracuda 80GB hard disk, and Intel 845GEVB2 motherboard. Recently, while downloading software from the net, my PC hung and after 15 or 20 seconds, my screen went completely black and displayed a message in blue with an error code "STOP: C000021a (fatal system error)". After this message, I shut down my PC and restarted it. Still, I keep getting this message: "Your computer has recovered from a critical error". I scanned my PC, but it didn't show any reason for the error messages. Is there a major problem?

Appu Sarkar

A 'STOP: C000021A' is an error that often occurs due to pending file-rename operations scheduled in the Windows XP registry that for some reason can't be completed. The software you were downloading is possibly an online installation program that scheduled a file to be renamed on the next restart of Windows. This is due to the file being in use and hence, cannot be deleted during the current session of Windows.

During the boot process, Windows registry checks for the file rename operation scheduled to be completed, and if it finds that the file or folder does not exist, then the above error is generated.

This error can be corrected using the registry editor. However, be warned that fiddling with the registry can be dangerous if not done with care. Use the registry editor at your own risk. Moreover, you will need to perform a parallel installation of Windows XP. A parallel installation of the operating system is an installation to the same drive and volume as an existing installation of Windows XP.

From the parallel installation of Windows XP, start the registry editor by going to **Start > Run** and entering `regedit` and clicking 'OK'. In the 'File' menu, click 'Load Hive' and type the path to the System hive of the original installation of Windows XP. This is typically:

`C:\Windows\System32\config\system`

Click 'Open'. When prompted for the name of the key, type 'TEST', and view the following registry entry: `HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\TEST`. Note the setting for the Current DWord value in the preceding registry key. This is represented as `CURRENT:Reg_DWord:0x1`. This indicates that the "CurrentControlSet" for your Windows XP installation corresponds to `ControlSet001`. A value of '2' indicates that `ControlSet002` will correspond to the "CurrentControlSet" of your original Windows XP installation. Locate the following registry key:

`HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\TEST\ControlSetXXX\Control\Session Manager` where XXX is the CurrentControlSet identified in the previous step. Under the 'Session Manager' key look for 'PendingFileRenameOperations' entries and delete them. Click 'TEST' hive, next, click the 'File' menu and click 'Unload Hive'. Again, click the 'File' menu and click 'Load Hive'. Locate and load the software hive of the original Windows XP, which are typically located at `C:\Windows\System32\config\Software`. When prompted for the key, enter `TEST2`. Here, look for and delete any PendingFileRenameOperations entries in the following registry keys:

`HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\TEST2\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\RunOnce`, and

`HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\TEST2\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\RunOnceEx`. Click on the `TEST2` hive and then click the 'File' menu and click 'Unload Hive'. Quit the registry editor and boot into the original installation of Windows XP.

To enable firewall in Windows XP SP2, follow these steps: Right-click on the 'Internet Connection' icon in the 'Network Connection', which is in the 'Control Panel' and click 'Properties'.

Next, click the 'Windows Firewall' tab and select the 'ON (recommended)' radio-button. Click 'OK'. Your firewall should now be enabled. If this doesn't work, your Service Pack 2 installation is probably corrupt, and you will have to re-install Service Pack 2.

A better option would be to install a third-party firewall such as Sygate Personal Firewall, which is free and can be downloaded from <http://snipurl.com/24pi>. It's much better than the firewall that comes free with Windows XP SP2.

Who Does This Computer Belong To?

Q I have two Operating Systems—Windows 98 SE on C: and Windows XP on D: drives. Whenever I format C:, or re-install Windows 98 SE, I lose the ability to boot into Windows XP, as its boot.ini file resides on C:, which gets deleted during reinstallation of Windows 98 SE. So, along with Windows 98, I also have to re-install Windows XP. Is there any other way to install Windows 98 without having to install Windows XP or to retain the boot.ini file?



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I have also tried copying the boot.ini file but that does not seem to work. I have a few music files with the extension .ram downloaded from Internet.

While trying to find a player for it on the Web, it refers to the 'Real Audio Media Player', which I later installed from the Digit DVD, but it could not play the above file. In its supported file list, .rm is present. I have many Hindi movie DVDs. Please suggest software to cut songs from the VOB files.

Soumyadeep Mitra

A As for your first question regarding multiple operating systems, refer to the answer provided in the Q&A section of the June 2005 issue of *Digit*.

The files with extension .RM and .RAM are Real Media files and can be played using RealPlayer basic version, which can be downloaded from www.real.com or using Real Alternative, which was carried in the June 2005 DVD of *Digit*. If you are still not able to play the file, chances are the file you have is corrupt.

There is a lot of software available to cut VOB files and save as AVI. Dr. DivX is one such software and can be downloaded from www.divx.com, and it's shareware. Another software, a freeware known as Vidomi can be downloaded from www.vidomi.com. ■